Niche /n*i:ʃ/*
Something suited to a particular context or purpose.

By Emma Stocklassa

Degree of Master of Fine Arts in Design – Spatial Design

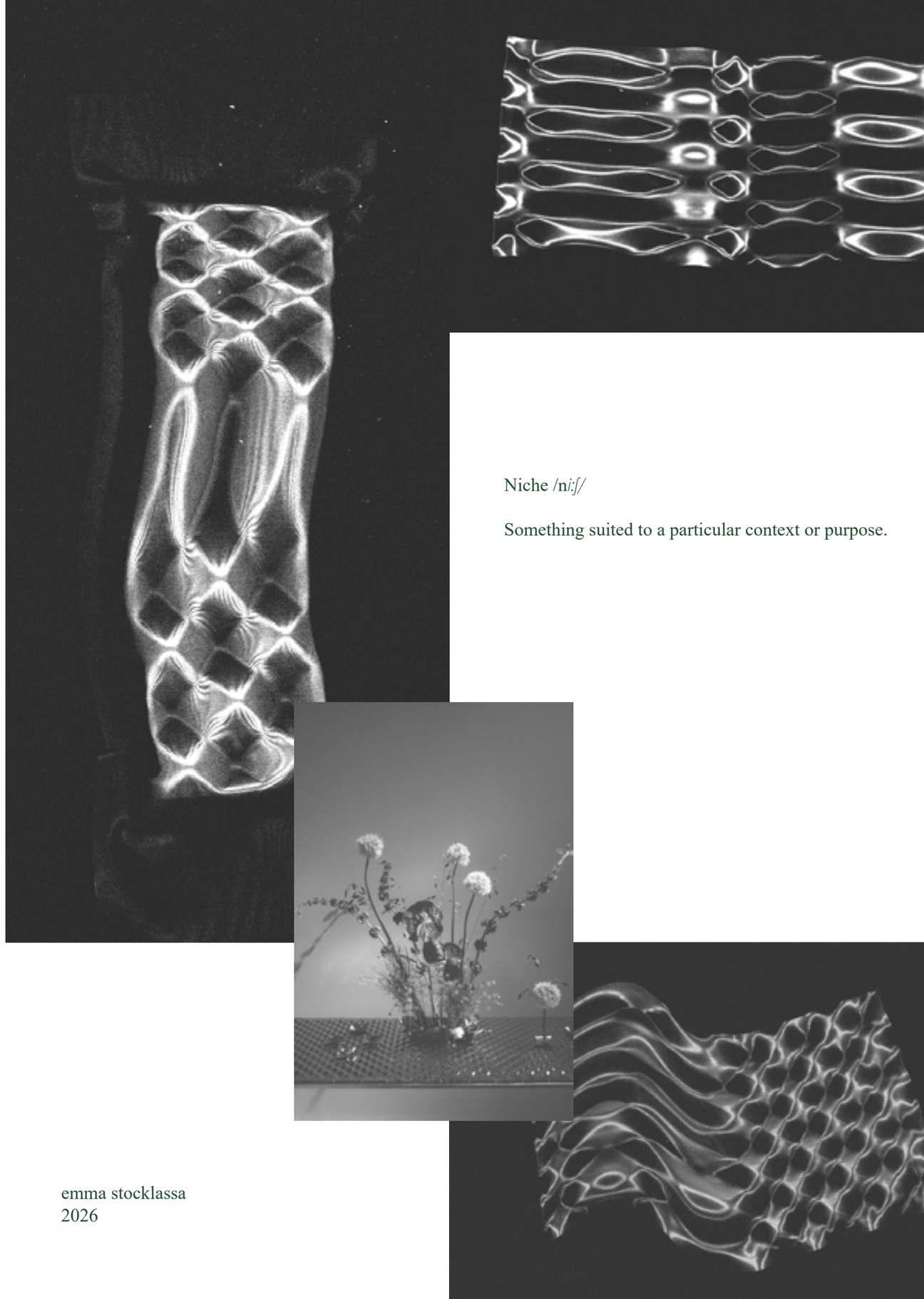
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Spring 2026



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KONSTFACK
University of Arts, Crafts and Design

emma stocklassa
2026

abstract

function isn't always practical

My degree project explores how function is constructed through the relationship between furniture design and their aesthetics, rather than existing as a fixed property of form. I question the assumption that good design must rely on a stable balance between practicality and visual expression, and instead investigate how functionality emerges through context, perception, and use. Through the development of a (what I see as) "semi-functional" dining table, I examine how practical, aesthetic, and communicative aspects interact, and how these conditions influence when an object is understood as functional.

The project is grounded in practice-based research. Through material experimentation I explored how a table could look that balances on a thin thread between functional and useless. I use the process of construction as a way of thinking,where the object itself is used to test the boundaries between usability and expression. The table is entirely made out of metal, and thanks to structural testing and shape prototyping, craft is used as a research method to investigate how function emerges through making.

This exploration sparked when the insight that functionality, particularly within modernist thinking, has been treated as a primary and stable value. However, many design objects are valued not only for their practical performance, but also for their aesthetic, symbolic, and cultural significance. By questioning how function is defined and understood, the project proposes that function is not inherent in objects but relational and contextual. In this sense, aesthetics can operate as a communicative dimension of function, and meaning can emerge even when practical use is incomplete. Ultimately, the project positions design not only as problem-solving, but as a reflective practice that challenges its own definitions and assumptions.

Keywords: function, aesthetics, semi-functionality, design, material exploration, practice-based research



[Fig 1.] sketches of ideas in an early stage

big thank you to

Jonas Majors – For your metal expertise

Emille De Blanche – For your help in the metal workshop

Lars Pettersson - For being my tutor

Helen Runting – For your help in writing this report

Also

FUJI Film

CGT Metall

Vink

Christoffers Blommor

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introduction

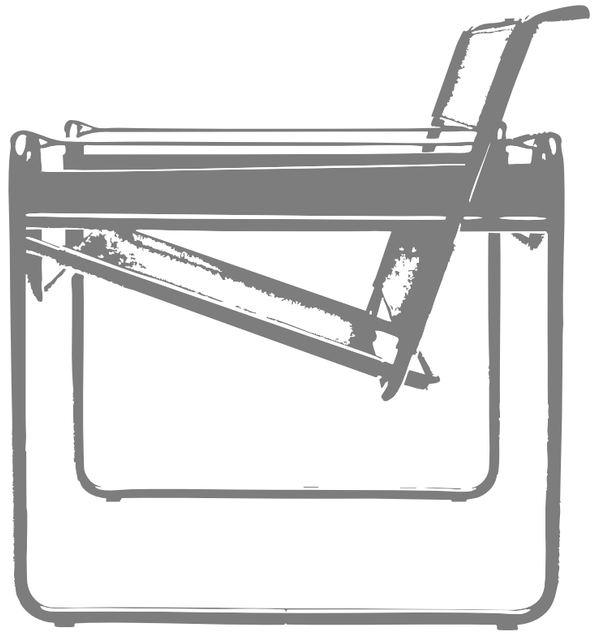
Since I began making furniture, I have often felt that my work does not conform to conventional ideas of functionality. Practicality has rarely been the primary concern in my design process, and I have generally felt comfortable with that position without questioning it. At times, however, I have wondered whether my furniture lacks a certain kind of function that it ought to possess. While the pieces have always been usable in their purpose, they would not necessarily be described as practical.

This led me to question whether function is truly an objective property of an object, or whether it is something that emerges through our interaction with it. A chair without a backrest remains a stool, but if it loses its seat, does it become non-functional? If a table has a soft surface, does it begin to resemble a bed? At what point does an object stop being what it is and become something else entirely?

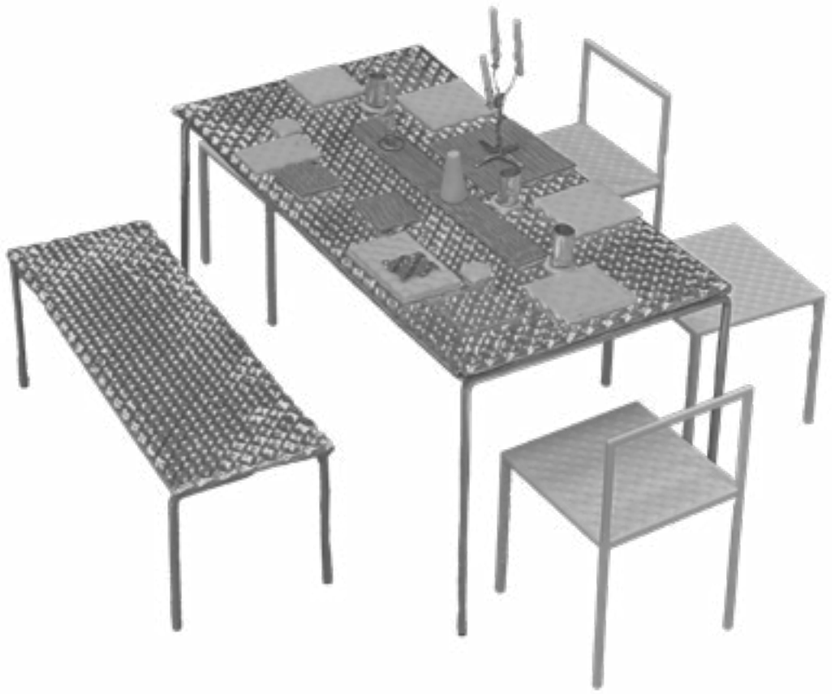
This project explores the idea that function is not a fixed and inherent property of objects, but rather something that is continuously negotiated through use, context, and perception. Instead of treating function as a stable and self-evident quality, I investigate how it is constructed and interpreted in relation to form, material, and user interaction.

Within modernist and functionalist design traditions, usefulness has often been regarded as the primary measure of quality. Yet many iconic design objects are valued not only for their practical performance but also for their cultural significance, aesthetic qualities, and symbolic meaning. The Wassily Chair, for example, is frequently celebrated despite several practical shortcomings. Its low seating position and steeply angled frame encourage a lounging posture that many users find uncomfortable. Nevertheless, it has been produced and sold in large numbers worldwide. This suggests that practical utility may not always be the defining characteristic we seek in furniture, and that other values can be equally important.

Through the development of a semi-functional dining table, this project investigates the threshold between functionality and non-functionality, and how this boundary shifts depending on context and interpretation. By focusing primarily on material experimentation, the project examines how furniture can occupy a position between use and unusability, challenging established assumptions about what function is and where it resides.



[Fig 2.] Illustration of Wassily chair by Marcel Breuer in 1925



[Fig 3.] model 1:10

purpose & research question

The purpose of this project is to reflect on the relationship between function and aesthetics within the field of furniture design. I question the assumption that these two qualities must always coexist in harmony, and I do so through material exploration and experimentation.

The aim of the project is to explore how function emerges and whether aesthetics can operate as a function in itself. I examine the boundaries between practical use and visual expression through the development of a semi-functional dining table. The project challenges the idea that an object must be fully operational to be considered successful design. Instead, it asks whether incompleteness, activation, and interpretation can form part of how function is understood, and whether an object can be considered non-functional when additional elements are required to make it function.

The central research questions of the project are:

How can a piece of furniture be designed to be considered “semi-functional”?

Is function inherent or relational?

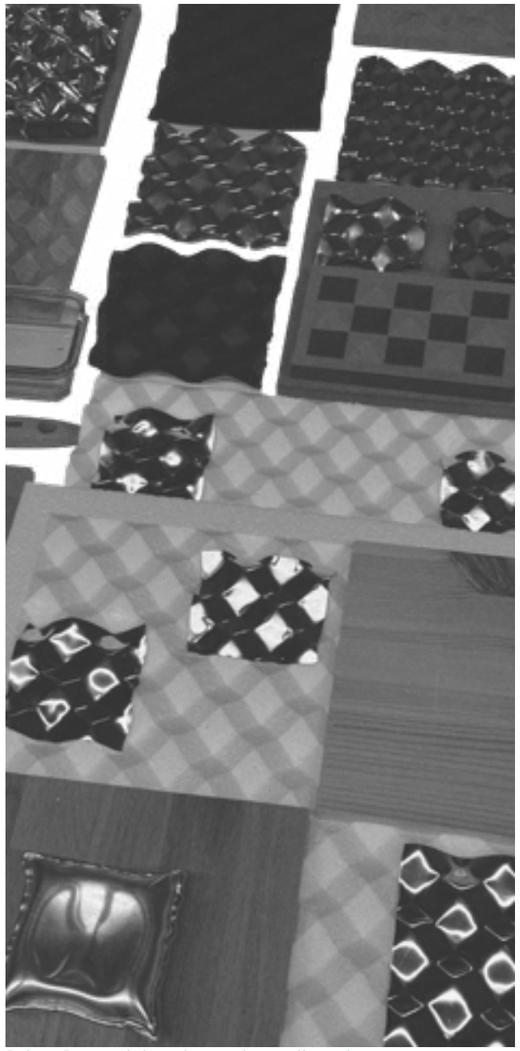
Can aesthetics operate as function?

To explore these questions, I conduct the project through practice-based research. I design and construct a full-scale dining table that is intentionally semi-functional, neither conventionally practical nor entirely useless. In its initial state, the table does not operate according to conventional expectations and requires additional crafted elements to activate its functionality. This reflects my interest in craft, which I further develop through a series of experiments that produce the components needed to complete the system of the semi-functional table. Through material experimentation, structural testing and prototyping, I use spatial and object design as methods of analysis. The process of making becomes a way of thinking and testing ideas, where construction, material choice, and scale all contribute to the investigation.

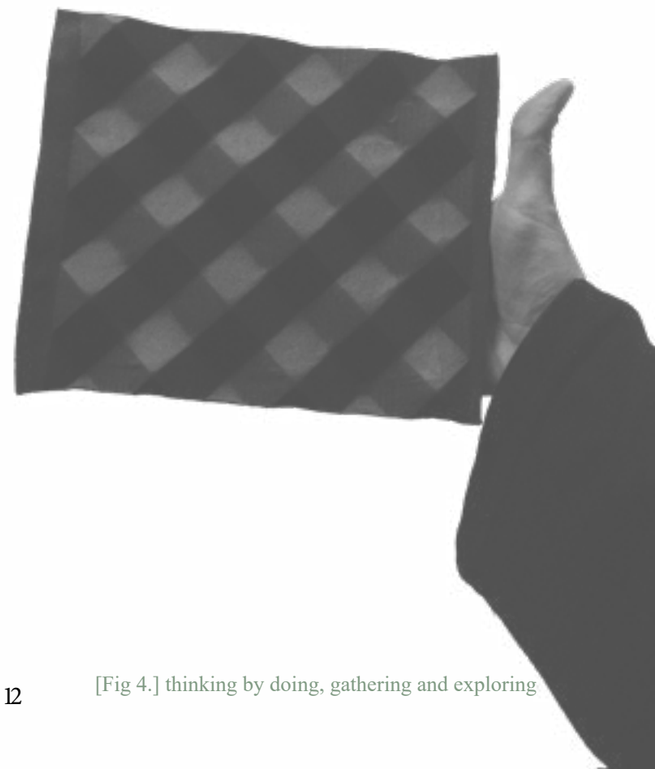
The choice of a dining table is intentional. The table is a highly recognisable and culturally loaded piece of furniture. It carries strong expectations of stability, usability, and social function. By working with such a familiar typology, even subtle shifts in function or structure become noticeable. The full-scale format allows the project to operate within real spatial conditions rather than as a model or speculation, making questions of use and interaction tangible.

While many designers explore the boundary between art and furniture, fewer projects focus specifically on the moment when functionality emerges, breaks down, or is negotiated - the point at which we decide to accept something as functional. By positioning the table between sculpture and furniture, this project contributes to an ongoing discussion about the role of design not only as problem-solving, but also as a form of critical reflection.

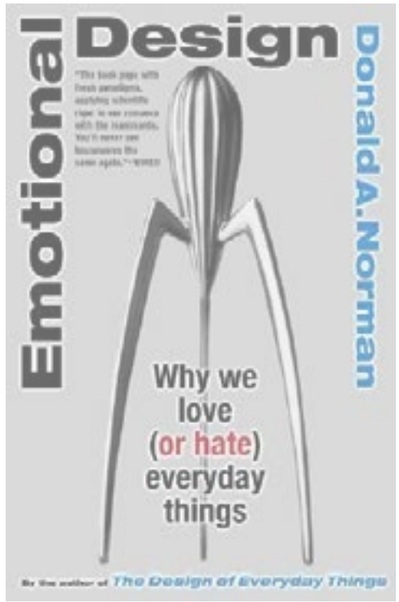
This project is relevant to the field of spatial design because it examines how objects define and influence space. A table is not only a tool but also a structure for social interaction and spatial organisation. By destabilising its functionality, the project explores how meaning and communication emerge through material and form.



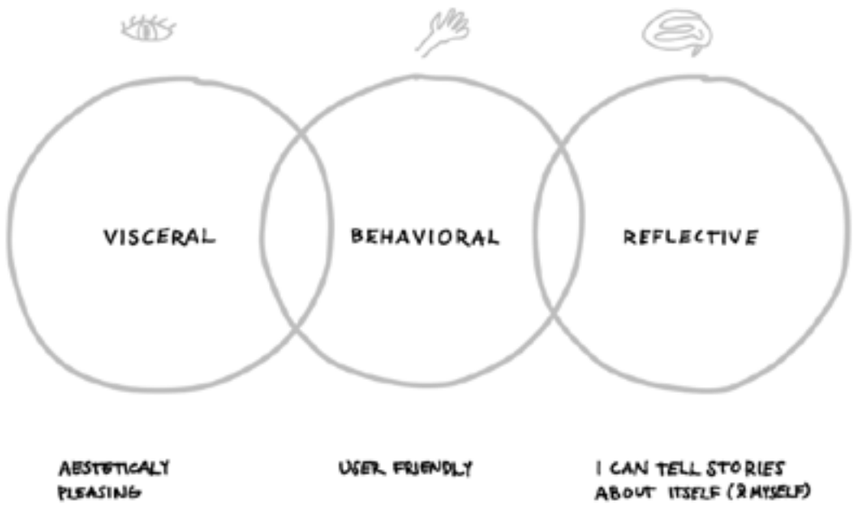
[Fig 5.] material testing and moodboards



[Fig 4.] thinking by doing, gathering and exploring



[Fig 6.] Emotional Design by Donald Norman 2003



[Fig 7.] Illustrations of Donald Normans' principals

theoretical framework

To ground my project theoretically, I looked for references that could provide a clearer cognitive framework. One example is *Emotional Design* by Don Norman, where he explores why we like and dislike objects by combining cognitive psychology, design theory, and behavioural science to describe three levels of design experience.

The first one is visceral design. This level concerns our immediate sensory response to an object. Elements such as form, colour, texture, weight, temperature, and visual appearance influence our instinctive reaction.

The second is behavioural design. This relates to usability and functionality, how well a product works, and how easy it is to understand and use. At this level, Norman also discusses the concept of affordances, meaning how design communicates what actions are possible. We, for example, naturally push a door with a plate, and pull a door with a handle.

The third one is a reflective design. This level concerns meaning, identity, and memory. It relates to how objects influence how we see ourselves, how we want to be perceived, and the emotional or cultural significance we attach to the objects. We also appreciate items that take up our attention, time and care, like a pour over or an old car.

A theory that is critical in my project, that Norman argues, is that aesthetically pleasing products work better, due to the user being more tolerant of small functional problems. Aesthetic objects make us more creative, which reflects our usage of objects. Therefore, visceral design is an important part of behavioural design.

Emotional Design therefore shows that emotion is not simply a bonus in design, but a fundamental part of how we experience and use objects.

what is function?

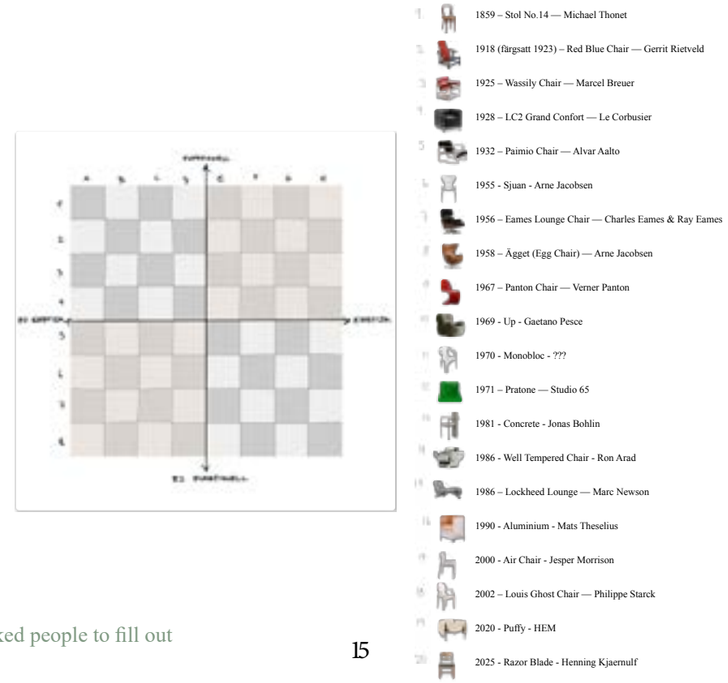
During the first week of my thesis work, mainly as a way to get started and explore the topic from a more informal angle, I conducted a small experiment. Participants were asked to place different chairs within a diagram based on their perceived aesthetic and functional value. The selection consisted of design classics from different decades and styles, chosen to create variation while still consisting of recognizable objects.

The participants varied in age, profession, gender, and background (between 27 and 63 years old), in order to obtain as broad a range of perspectives as possible. After reading *Emotional Design*, I analyzed the responses and surprisingly found patterns that seemed to support some of Norman's theories.

One clear pattern was that the more aesthetic an object was perceived to be, the more functional it was also considered. This aligns with Norman's idea that aesthetic appeal influences how we judge usability, suggesting that visual design plays a strong role in our initial interpretation of function.

Another pattern was that older objects were more often rated as aesthetic. This may be linked to stronger emotional connections formed over time through history, cultural familiarity, or personal memory, which can enhance their reflective qualities.

In contrast, newer designs tended to generate more divided opinions. This could be because we have not yet formed strong emotional or cultural relationships with them, meaning they are evaluated in a more immediate or uncertain way, without established trust or recognition.



[Fig 8.] My survey I asked people to fill out

what is semi-functional?

To define semi-functionality, I wanted to investigate the term more closely. What does "semi-functional" actually mean? By breaking down the word, I explored the prefix "semi". According to the dictionary, it means "half," "partly," or "to some extent." It describes something that is neither fully one thing nor another, but exists in-between.

The prefix allows something to be incomplete while still belonging to a category. For example, semi-transparent glass allows light through but obscures visibility. Semi-permanent hair dye lasts for a limited time but is not permanent. A semifinal is the stage before the final, where something is close to completion but not yet fully there.

Without the prefix "semi," these meanings would change completely. Glass would either be transparent or opaque. Hair dye would either be permanent or temporary. A competition would simply end in a final without transitional stages. "Semi" therefore introduces a grey zone where definitions become flexible.

Functionality, according to the dictionary, is defined as "the quality of being suited to serve a purpose well" and also "the purpose that something is designed or expected to fulfil." This raises a question: are we referring to practical performance or intended purpose? These do not necessarily need to align.

Historically, the term "functionality" appears in language around the 19th century, with increased usage during the rise of functionalism in the 1930s. However, objects were functional long before this terminology became common. This suggests that the word itself may reflect a shift in how we describe rather than how we use objects.

reference - emotional design

grace – mats theselius

Would you buy an armchair for 125,000 SEK? Especially if you could get a similar one from the same designer and brand for a fraction of the price? Sounds not like a good deal right? But what if I told you that the armchair was partially made out of parts from the church where you were married or your children baptized? Well, the answer is still no perhaps, but you might be more willing to, due to you having a personal connection to the chair, right from the start.

The chair *Grace*, designed by Mats Theselius for Källemo (2023), incorporates copper reclaimed from the roof of a church undergoing renovation. This material carries strong personal and cultural associations, even though the copper itself has no direct connection to personal memory.

When I worked in a store selling these chairs, all 223 pieces were sold within a few months. Customers often shared personal stories connected to the church, weddings, baptisms, childhood memories. These emotional connections became part of the value of the object.

This demonstrates how function in design can extend beyond practical use, operating instead through memory, identity, and cultural meaning.



[Fig 9.] Grace by Mats Theselius in 2023. Photo: Källemo

reference - staged design

stockholm town hall

Stockholm Town Hall
An interesting reference that shows a different perspective on design strategies is Stockholm City Hall by Ragnar Östberg in 1908. It was designed to appear older than it is, which can be understood as a form of reflective identity design. The building is intentionally constructed asymmetrically to evoke a medieval character, as historical buildings were often developed in stages over time. This effect is carefully orchestrated while still intended to read as “accidental.” Subtle shifts in the façade, towers placed off-center, and variations in window placement all contribute to the impression that the building has evolved over several centuries, even though it was conceived as a unified design.

The brickwork is also hand-made in a traditional manner, giving the façade a tactile, almost aged quality from the outset. Ragnar Östberg integrated numerous historically referential details, which are nonetheless newly designed interpretations rather than direct reproductions of older architecture. Rather than imitating a specific historical building, Stockholm City Hall constructs a staged sense of history and permanence through carefully orchestrated architectural decisions.

[Fig 10.] Stockholm Town Hall from 1908 by Ragnar Östberg. Photo: Stockholm Stad





[Fig 11.] Angostura Bitter Poster. Photo: Angostura Bitter

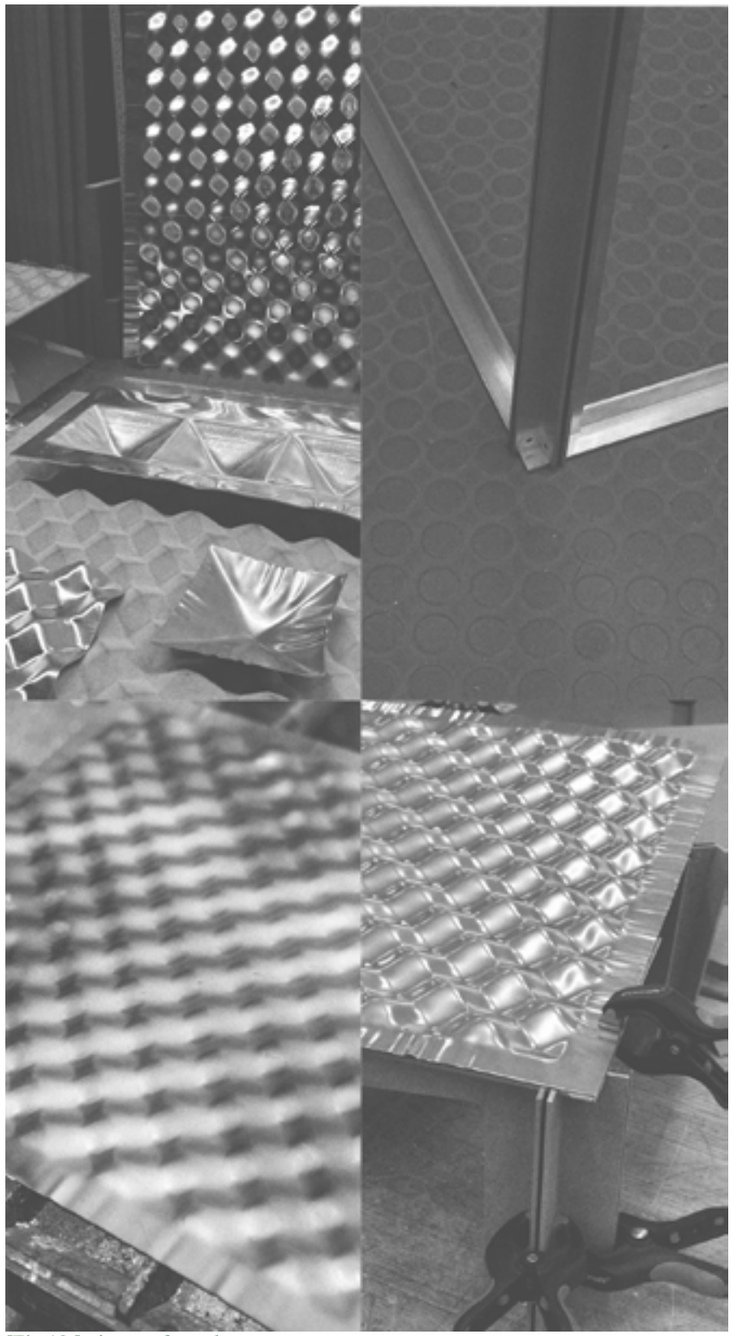
reference - bad design turns brilliant

angostura bitter

You might have noticed the bottle of Angostura bitters at Systembolaget, known for its distinctive design that resembles a label too large for the bottle.

The product was originally developed by Dr. Johann Siegert in 1824. After his death, his sons took over the business and entered various competitions around the world to grow sales. Before one competition, they accidentally ordered labels in the wrong size, resulting in labels that were too large for the bottles.

The mistake was not corrected in time, and the product was entered into the competition with the oversized label. Although it did not win, one of the judges commented positively on its striking visual identity. As a result, the “mistake” was never corrected, and it became a defining feature of the brand. This is an example of how a perceived “bad” visual design can evolve into strong reflective design.



[Fig 12.] pictures from the process

method

My design process mainly involves material experimentation, primarily with metal but also with other materials. One of the objects I create is a table, which has a relatively simple function: to provide a surface on which objects can be placed. Normally, this requires the tabletop to be flat, hard, stable, and level. These are fairly straightforward requirements, but where does the boundary between functional and non-functional design lie?

I explore several possibilities. Should the tabletop be soft, tilted, or perforated? Eventually, I decide that the surface should be uneven, while still allowing the user to influence it in a way that makes it functional.

I use *visceral* design to create a textured surface that is visually and tactically engaging, behavioural design to introduce partial usability, and reflective design by allowing the user to activate and complete the object through interaction. In this way, the user becomes part of the design process.

material exploration

pattern

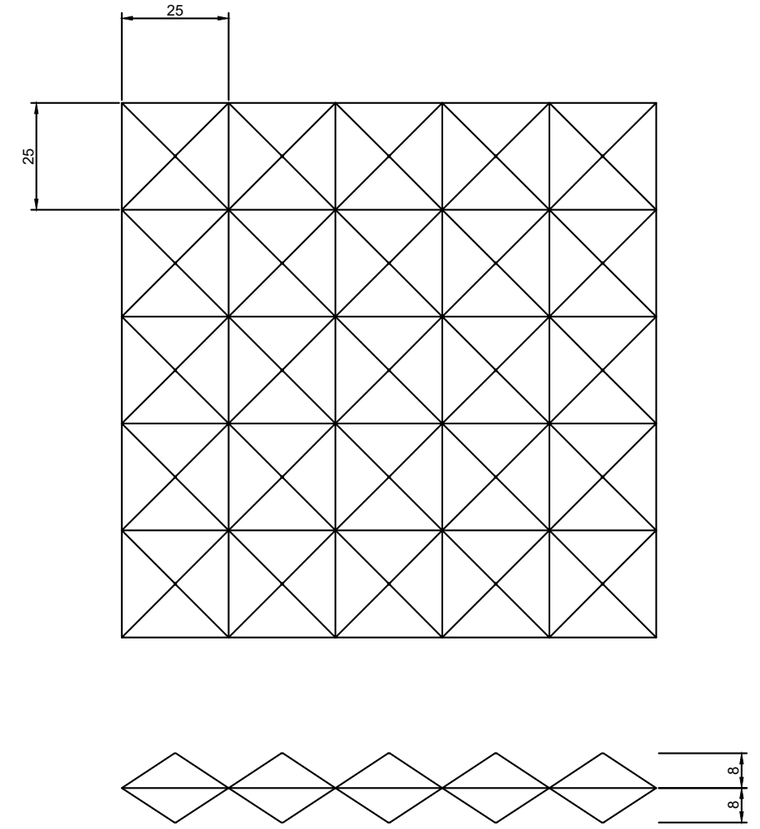
In recent years, I primarily focus on working with metal. At the beginning of this project, I consider working with wood, a material I have also explored extensively in previous years. Some of my early sketches incorporate wooden elements, but I ultimately return to metal, partly because of its aesthetic qualities and partly because of its structural potential.

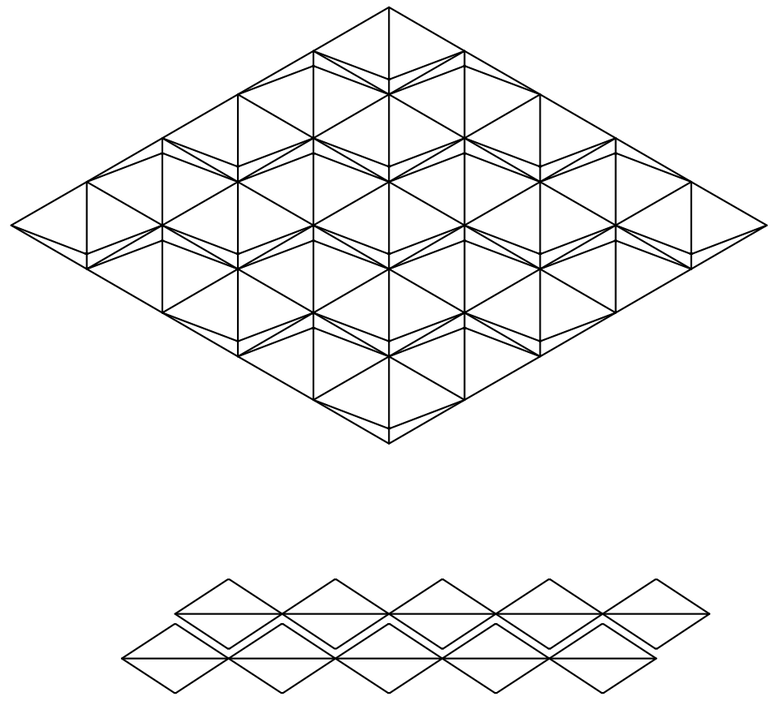
The project begins with an interest in creating an obstructed table surface. I do not want the surface to appear purely organic or irregular; instead, I aim for a highly controlled and modular system. The pattern requires a clear internal logic that allows elements to fit together, rotate, and interact with additional components.

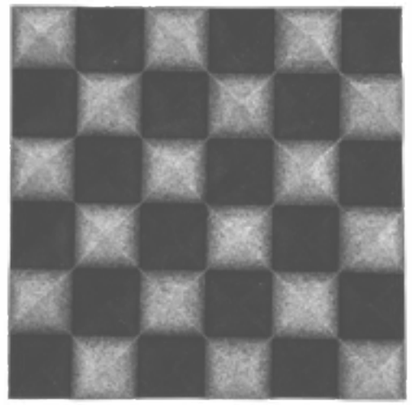
This leads to the development of a textured surface with a scale large enough to be perceived as structure rather than ornamentation, yet small enough to remain legible as a surface.

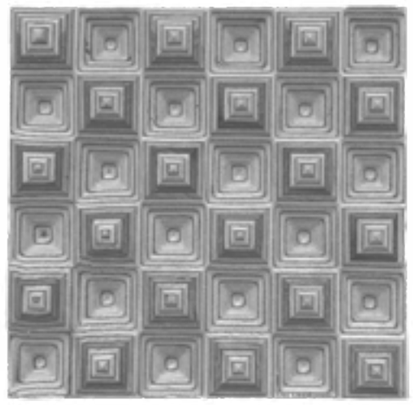
To develop the pattern, I experiment with different forms and proportions. The final pattern consists of pyramid-shaped modules measuring 25 × 25 mm with a height and depth of 8 mm. Each module has a square base with 90-degree corners and sides inclined at 33 degrees.

The system allows rotation, flipping, and stacking, making it possible to layer multiple sheets and combine them in different configurations.











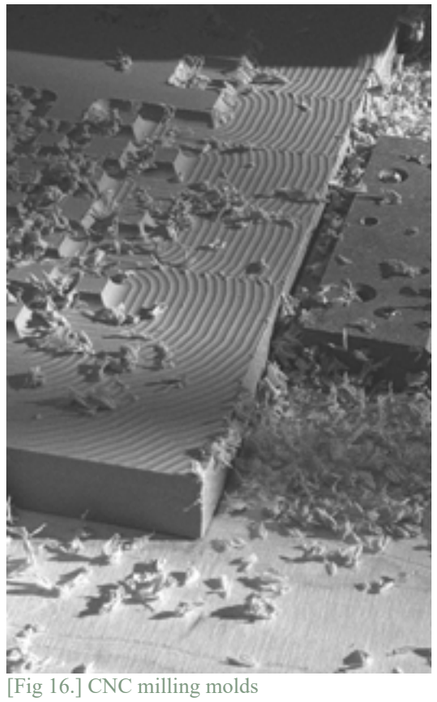
from top:
[Fig 13.] mdf & valchromat
[Fig 14.] plywood
[Fig 15.] oak

cnc milling and mold development

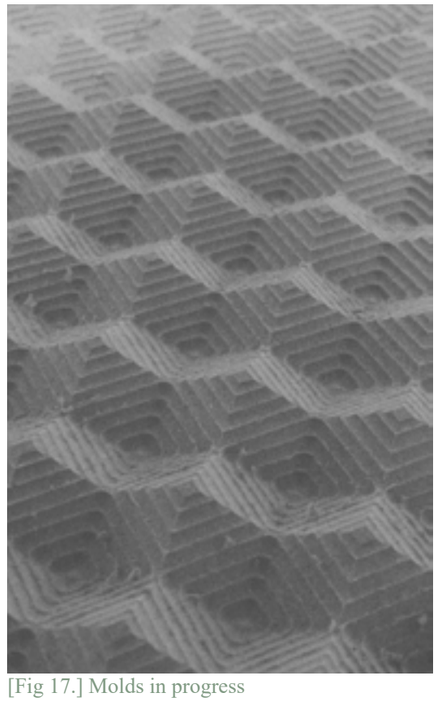
After developing the pattern, I began producing prototypes of the texture. I have worked with many different methods throughout my material explorations, with a focus on CNC milling and hydraulic pressing. CNC milling became an important tool both for developing textures and for producing the press molds used later in the process.

The method involves modelling a form in a 3D program, in my case Rhino, after which a computer-controlled milling machine carves out the structure. I used CNC milling to develop prototypes of the textures I wanted to create, to produce textured objects, and to fabricate the molds themselves.

I experimented with milling in several different materials. In wood, the grain created natural shifts in tone and depth, while MDF mainly produced shadows and a sense of spatial dimensionality. I also experimented with milling into glued coloured Valchromat mounted on MDF, which created an additional grid-like colour pattern within the texture, as the deeper the milling went, the more the coloured Valchromat became visible. Although this technique was not included in the final outcome, it is something I would like to continue exploring in the future.



[Fig 16.] CNC milling molds



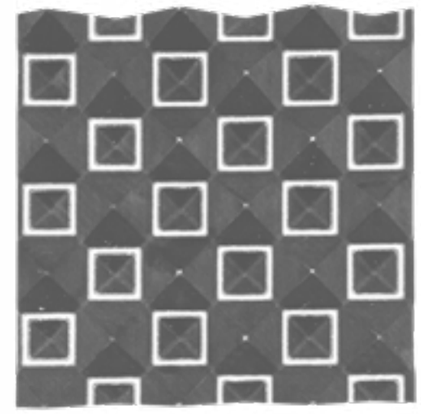
[Fig 17.] Molds in progress

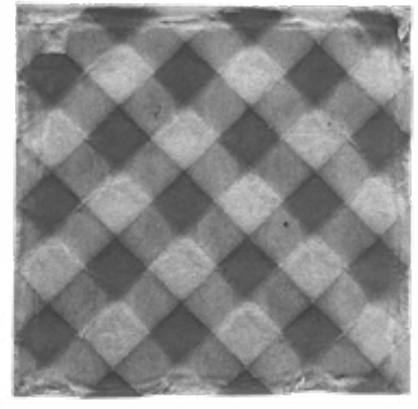
material and hydraulic press testing

The CNC-milled molds later became central to my experiments with hydraulic pressing. I used a positive and a negative mold to press the pattern into the metal as sharply as possible. I tested many different approaches to pressing metal, but the process proved extremely difficult.

The pattern itself made it challenging for the molds to withstand the pressure of the hydraulic press, where I sometimes used up to 500 tons of force. Mold after mold failed, becoming flattened, worn down, or completely crushed under the pressure. At the same time, the metal sheets repeatedly cracked in different ways, often at the most exposed points of the texture, at the peaks and valleys created through milling, since the material needed to stretch more in these areas in order to form the intended geometry. Finding a balance where both mold and metal sheet survived, while still producing a clear and defined texture, became one of the main challenges of the project.

I started with MDF molds, but the material proved too soft. I achieved a pattern, but it became more wavy and organic than intended. I then tested compressed laminate, which was hard enough to resist the pressure but too rigid, causing the mold to crack and crumble in certain areas. Eventually, I developed molds in nylon plastic, an industrial plastic material that was hard enough to maintain its shape but still flexible enough not to crack and break under controlled conditions. After many, and truly many, failed attempts, this finally enabled the successful pressing of a 0.7 mm thick metal sheet.





from top:
[Fig 18.] compressed laminate
[Fig 19.] mdf

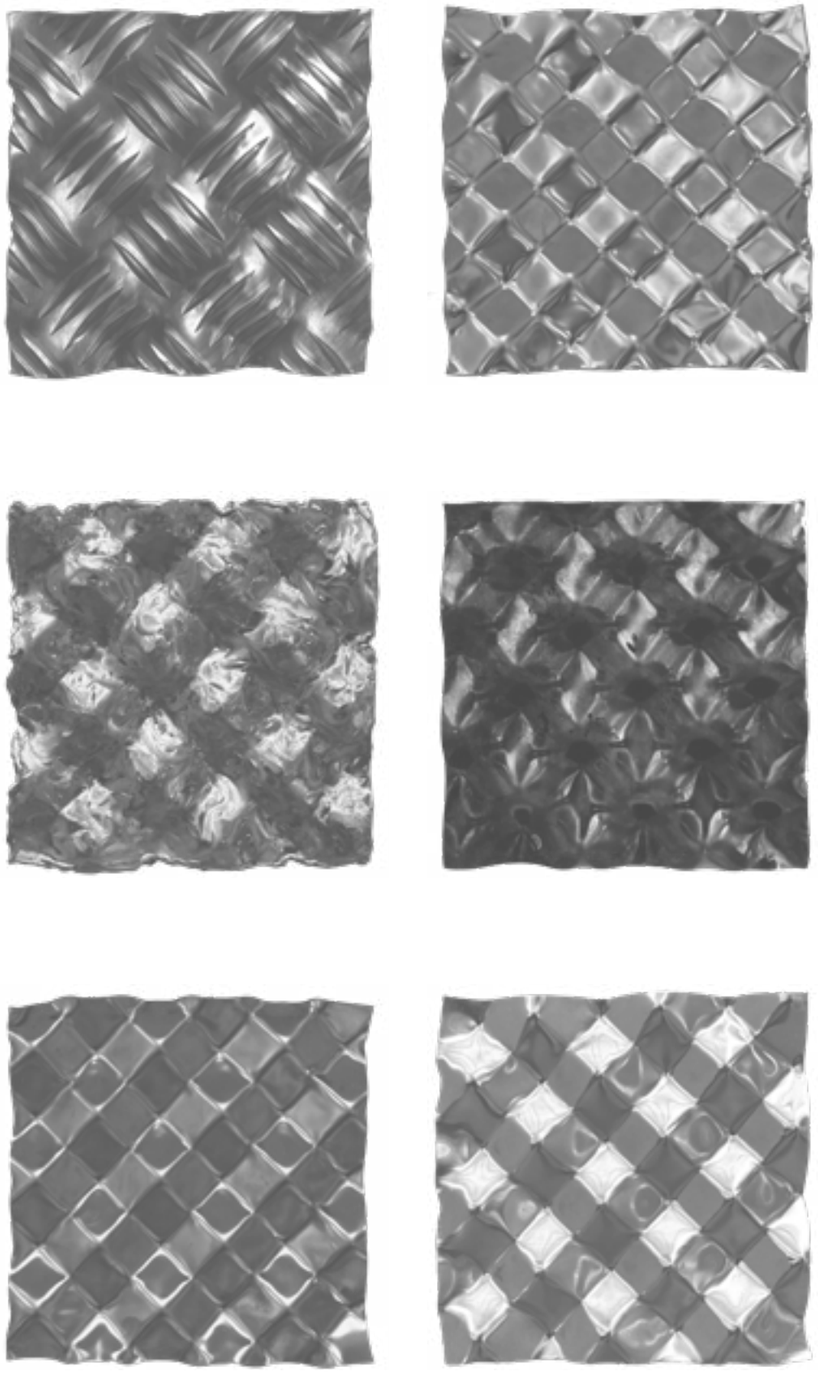
hydraulic pressing

I experimented with pressing several different materials, including aluminium, steel, tempered steel, stainless steel, and leather. Each material responded differently depending on the intended result.

Aluminium was soft and produced elegant forms, while also allowing relatively thick sheets between 1 and 4 mm to be pressed. However, when increasing the scale, the material often cracked due to increasing tension in the surface. Stainless steel, on the other hand, was significantly harder, roughly three times harder than aluminium, which meant I mainly worked with thinner sheets between 0.5 and 1 mm. Although it required much higher pressure, sometimes up to 500 tons, the material did not crack as easily and maintained its structural integrity. Leather behaved completely differently and, when soaked beforehand, only required around 200 tons of pressure to take the form.



[Fig 20.] leather
[Fig 21.] glass
[Fig 22.] vacuum formed plastic



[Fig 23.] checker plate
[Fig 24.] melted aluminium
[Fig 25.] brushed steel
[Fig 26.] raw aluminium
[Fig 27.] tempered steel
[Fig 28.] polished steel



[Fig 29.] Hydraulic pressing in process

process development and large-scale pressing

After experimenting with smaller surfaces, I moved on to larger scales and eventually to my table surface measuring 60 × 150 cm. Before reaching this stage, however, I failed many times. The hydraulic press could only press approximately 25 × 25 cm at a time, which meant I needed to match and shift the sheet throughout the mold in order to press the surface in sections. I made multiple attempts, and the results often failed because I did not align the pattern accurately enough, which made the seams visible.

In the end, I succeeded by working with two separate molds. The first mold created a soft, wavy base structure in the metal sheet, almost like a preparation for the final press. The second mold then pressed the actual texture into this pre-formed surface. This method made it possible to work section by section without visible seams between the pressed areas.

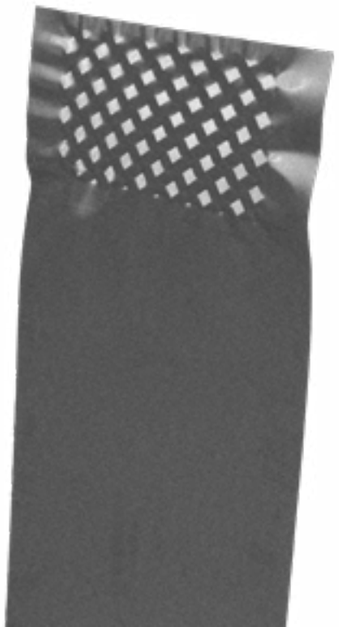
The final texture was pressed in sections of approximately 25 × 25 cm, overlapping each other and repeated three to four times across the entire sheet, with an incremental increase of approximately 150 tons per pressing stage. Once this process worked successfully, I continued working with thicker 1 mm metal sheets.

the production process was very challenging

the molds often failed under the pressure of the hydraulic press,
and the metal sheets frequently cracked or deformed

...looks like I am not the only one cracking under pressure...

[Fig 30.] partially pressed metallsheet



surface development and structural logic

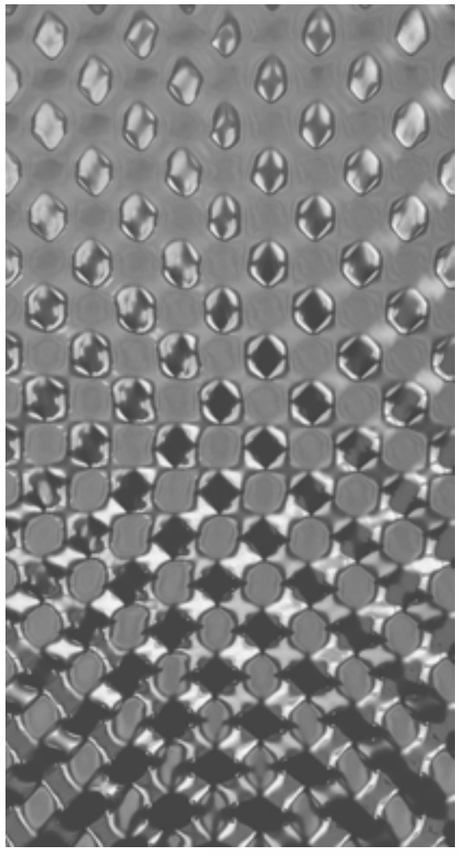
During the pressing process, I realized that the texture I was developing carried significant structural strength. Rather than ignoring this, I chose to integrate it as a central part of the design.

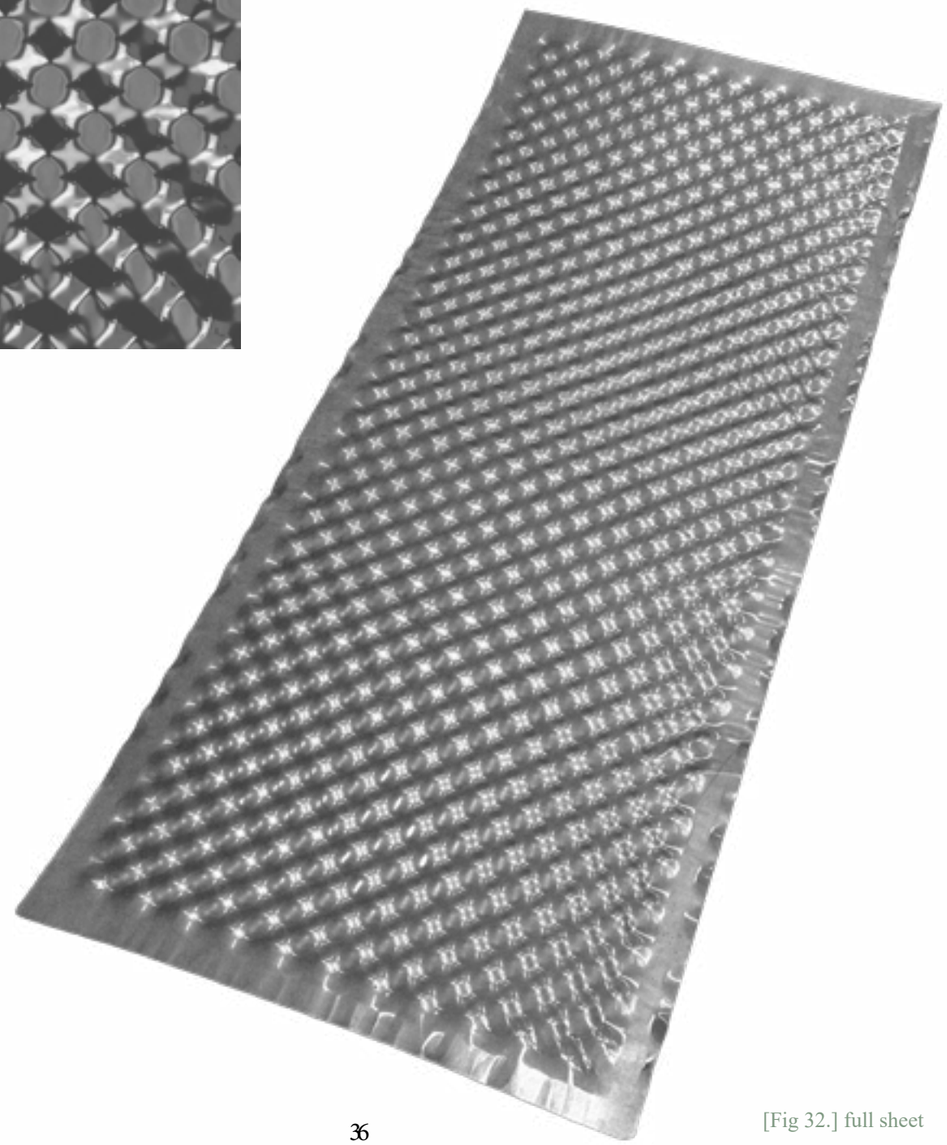
The structure resembled principles found in egg-carton and honeycomb systems and reflected several established structural logics.

A key principle was that dome-like geometries distributed pressure across the surface rather than concentrating it at a single point. Based on this, I made a conscious decision to use square geometries instead of hexagonal ones. This allowed elements to be rotated in 90-degree increments, increasing modular flexibility. If a hexagonal, six-sided system had been used, the elements would only have rotated in 60-degree increments, which would have limited reversibility and reduced adaptability.

In addition, the depth of the texture, 16 mm, significantly increased stiffness, similar to how folded or corrugated materials became stronger than flat sheets. The folds created internal tension, where structural forces supported each other across the surface. It was at this point that I realized that a 1 mm sheet alone would not have been able to maintain the structural stability required for a table without supporting elements, but in my case the texture itself became the structural reinforcement of the object.

[Fig 31.] texture





[Fig 32.] full sheet



[Fig 33.] table

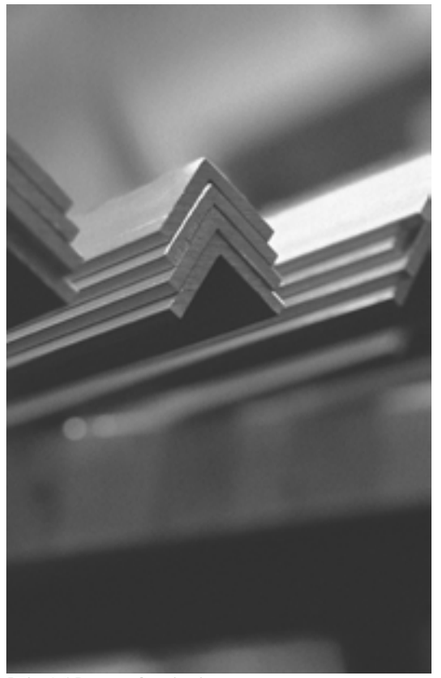


[Fig 34.] table leg

base design

When designing the base, I chose to work with a more industrial aesthetic in order for the table to be interpreted as technical rather than organic. Since the wavy pattern could easily be perceived as overly bohemian or decorative, I wanted the base to create a strong contrast and balance the expression of the tabletop.

The base is therefore constructed from V-shaped steel profiles assembled into a frame using mortise and tenon joints, where the legs are attached with visible screws. Between each element of the legs there is a spacing equal to the thickness of the V-profiles, creating a sense of lightness and refinement.



[Fig 36.] parts for the legs



[Fig 35.] cutting parts for the base

glass slumping

Once the metal sheets were completed, some of them were used for glass slumping, a process in which glass is slowly heated and shaped without becoming fully molten. Using these molds, I produced yellow glass dishes in different shapes and dimensions.

What fascinated me throughout this process was how many separate steps were required to create the final objects, while each individual step also resulted in something that could almost exist as a finished object in itself. This brought me back to my original question: why do we perceive certain objects as functional?

Even though each stage was not the final product, every part still had a function because it was necessary for the next step. This suggests that function is not fixed, but instead dependent on context, process, and the number of purposes an object is able to fulfill.

[Fig 37.] trays made out of slumped glass



[Fig 38.] Metal sheet as a mold for glass slumping

[Fig 39.] the Niche Table



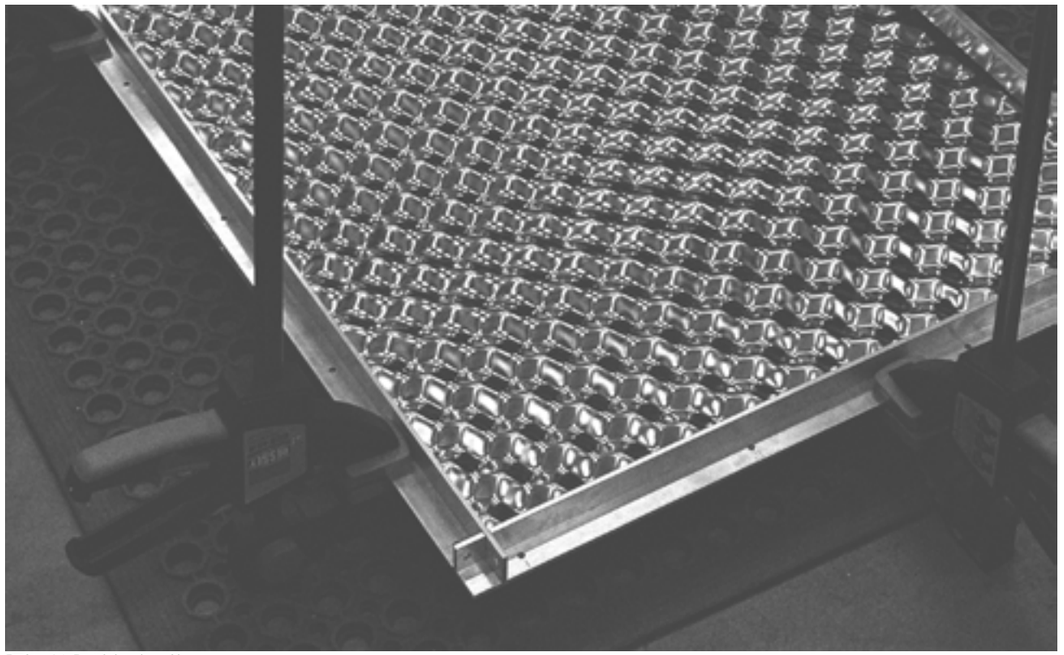
[Fig 40.] the four stools

result

The main outcome of the project became a table that is intentionally semi-functional. A table top is usually smooth, stable, perfectly horizontal and, most often, warm and inviting. Here, the idea of semi-functionality reveals the opposite. A tabletop with a pronounced texture, a cold, hard and glossy surface. Some would perceive it as hostile, others as fascinating, and some as both. This tabletop rests on an industrial base constructed from aluminium profiles in a technically advanced structure. It is assembled with Chicago screws, which are flush on both sides, creating a stripped and reduced visual impression.

The tabletop includes a set of components, activators. One of the most prominent is the bowl and the vase. The bowl, which is pyramid-shaped, sits firmly within the unevenness of the surface, almost affirming its imperfection as something positive. Without it, the bowl would not be usable; it would be unstable and tilt. Here, both components depend on each other equally.

For this table I created two stools with the same expression, and two that reflect my earlier exploration of “semi-functional” furniture.



[Fig 41.] table details



[Fig 42.] process picture

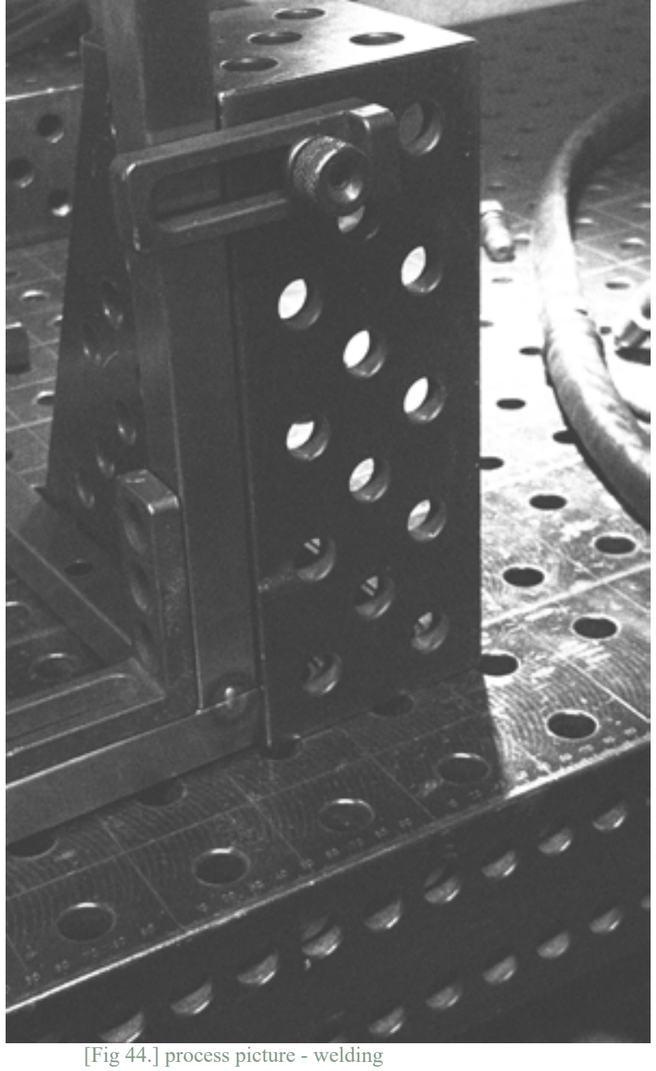
stool 01

Stool 01 is essentially my test subject. It has a minimal seat, extremely tall proportions, a rather unstable balance, and a sharp-edged seat. Some see it as a side table, others as a bar stool. I see it as my experimental prototype. It contains tabs and slots that I later used in the structure of the table, as well as the tabletop, spacers and material choices being consistent. Even though it is only a test piece, I include it in the final result, as the process is part of the outcome in itself.

niche side stool
a test of connections and joinery
an aluminium base
with
a textured seat / top



[Fig 43.] stool 01



[Fig 44.] process picture - welding

stool 02

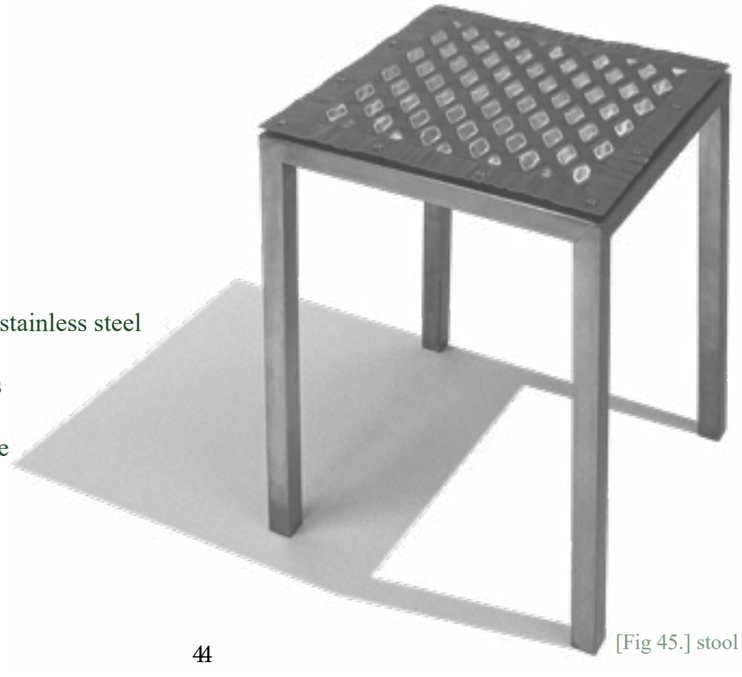
Stool 02 is a companion to the table. The texture of the seat matches the tabletop, which I initially believed would push discomfort to its limit, but instead the stool turned out to be surprisingly comfortable. I am unsure how it would feel over an entire dinner, but it is certainly not as uncomfortable as one might expect. In this version, the seat is brushed, as is the frame. The frame is also welded into a single continuous structure, where the brushing creates the illusion of mitered corners. Here as well, I have used spacers to further align the expression with the table.

niche stool, with a textured seat in stainless steel

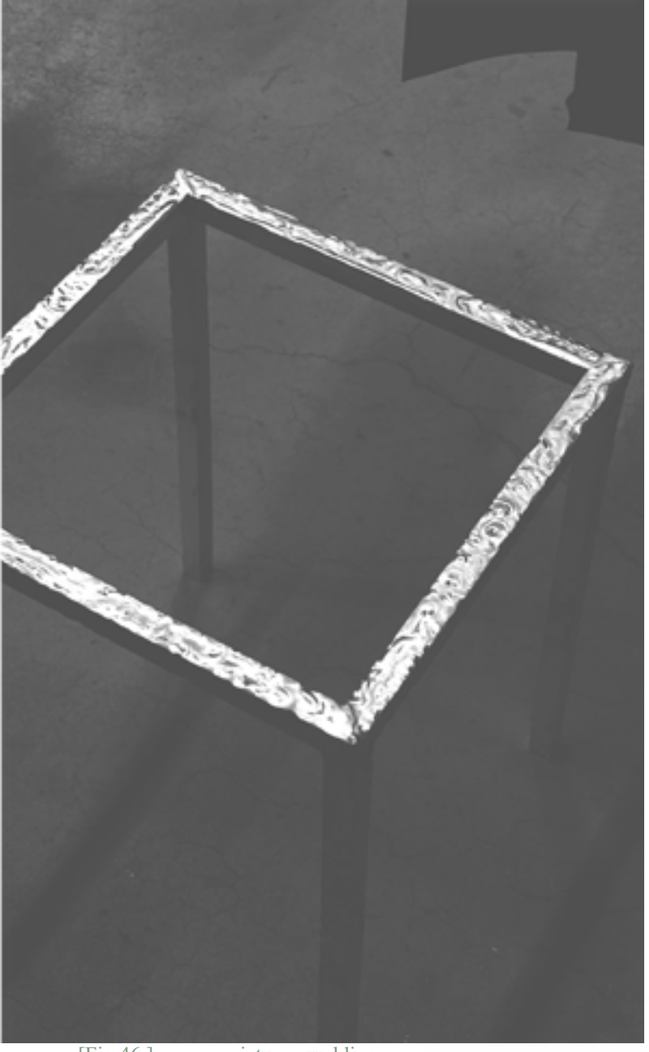
resting with distances

on a brushed steel base

a friend to the table



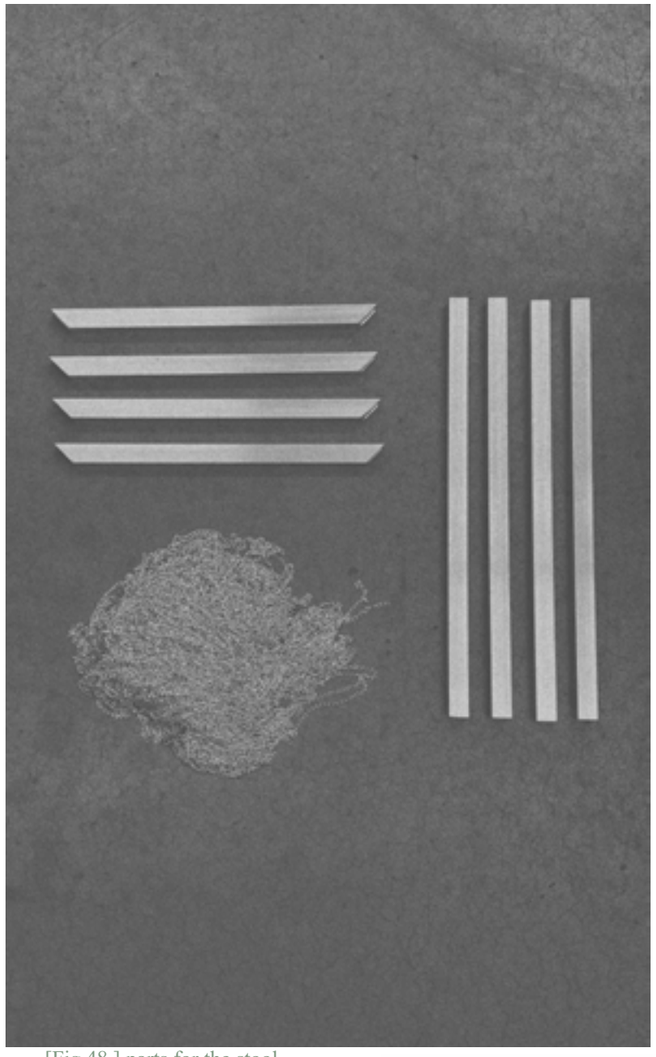
[Fig 45.] stool 02



[Fig 46.] process picture - welding

stool 03

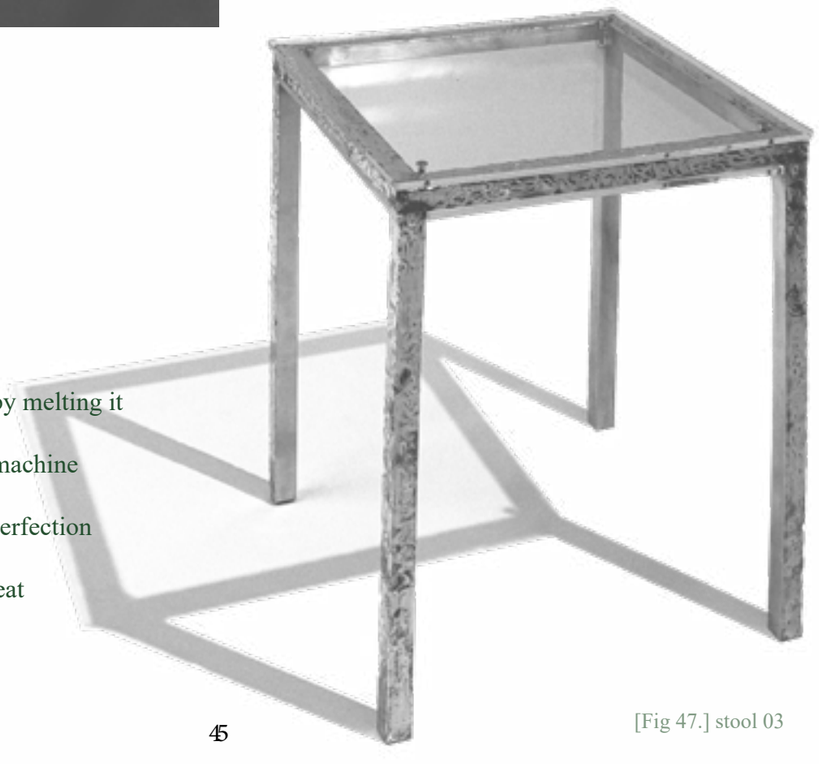
Stool 03 shares the same frame as Stool 02, but is executed in aluminium. Here, I have fused the outer surfaces using TIG welding and polished the surface into a mirror finish. This gives the frame a cast-like appearance, while the interior still hints at its industrial origin. On this frame, I have placed an acrylic seat so the structure remains visible, but also to introduce a slight provocation by presenting the illusion of an unfinished chair, almost like a skeleton.



[Fig 48.] parts for the stool

stool 04

Stool 04 also uses the same frame as the previous stools, this time in brushed aluminium. On top sits an acrylic plate, and within it a secondary plate from which chains are suspended. The chains create the illusion of a thicker structural frame. This is inspired by my bachelor's degree project, where I created two cabinets based on the same principle.



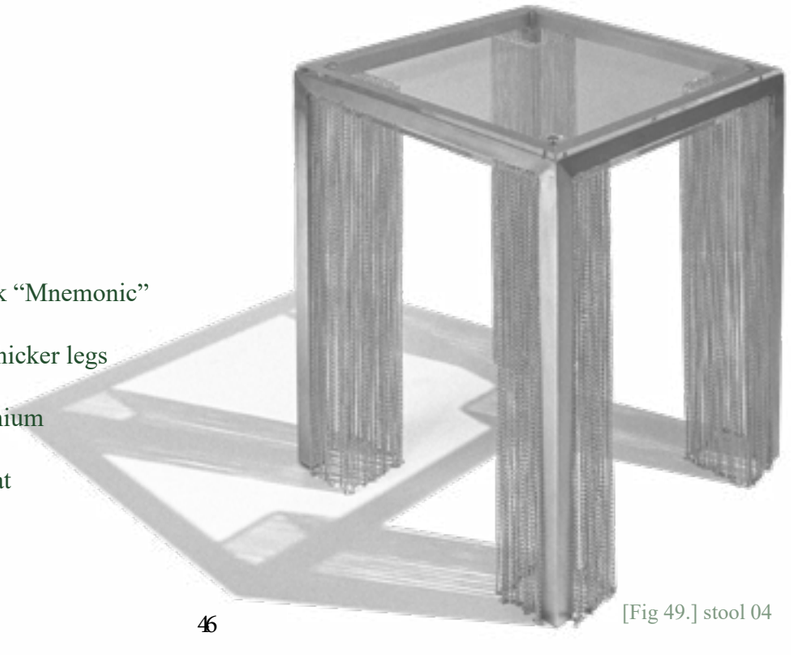
[Fig 47.] stool 03

"destroying" a finished base by melting it

sculpted with a welding machine

polished to a mirrored imperfection

acrylic sheets as a seat



[Fig 49.] stool 04

small homage to my previous work "Mnemonic"

chains creating an illusion of thicker legs

a base in brushed aluminium

acrylic sheets as a seat

discussion

from conceptual question to material investigation

This degree project investigates how function is constructed within design rather than existing as a fixed and inherent property of objects. Through the development of a semi-functional dining table, the project explores the threshold between functionality and non-functionality, and how this boundary is continuously negotiated through material, context, and perception.

The initial aim of the project was to question the assumption that good design requires a stable balance between function and aesthetics. Instead, the project started from the idea that function itself might be unstable, relational, and dependent on context. The proposal was grounded in practice-based research, where making functioned as a method of inquiry. Throughout the process, theory and practice were not separated, but continuously informed one another through material experimentation, construction, and iteration.

What began as a conceptual question about function gradually developed into a material investigation. Through CNC milling, hydraulic pressing, and repeated material testing, the project shifted from abstract speculation to physical negotiation with material resistance. Failures in production and structural limitations became central to the development of the work, and the material process itself became a way of testing and refining the research question.

Throughout the process, I navigate a set of uncertainties. I question whether I lean too far into theory or not far enough, and whether clarity is lost along the way. I also consider the possibility that the project's intentions may not be fully understood, and that what I aim to communicate may not be perceived as intended. In particular, I question how the term "semi-functional" is received, whether it is understood as a deliberate exploration or misinterpreted as a failure.

key findings

One of the key insights of the project is that function is not a stable condition located within an object, but something that emerges through relations between material, user, and context. Function is therefore not inherent, but constructed through interaction.

A second insight is that aesthetics plays an active role in this construction. Rather than being separate from function, visual and tactile qualities influence how usability is perceived and can determine whether an object is understood as functional at all. In this sense, aesthetics can be understood as a communicative dimension of function.

A third insight is that incompleteness can be productive. The semi-functional state of the table creates a situation where interpretation and activation become necessary for the object to function.



[Fig 50.] picture of the bowls and vases and how they fit in to the table

project outcome

The main outcome is a full-scale dining table that is intentionally semi-functional. The tabletop is not immediately usable in a conventional sense, but requires additional crafted components such as bowls, vases, and other activating elements to achieve functional stability. In this system, function is distributed rather than fixed and emerges through interaction between parts rather than residing within a single object.

Alongside the table, a series of stools were developed as extensions of the same design logic. These objects explore variations in material expression, structural behaviour, and usability, further testing how function can shift while still being perceived as design rather than failure.



[Fig 51.] my project during the spring exhibition

evaluation

strengths

One of the strongest aspects of the project is the integration of material experimentation with conceptual inquiry. The iterative process of testing materials and structures created a direct feedback loop between idea and matter, allowing the project to evolve through failure, adjustment, and observation.

Another strength is the consistency of the design language across the table and stools, where each object operates as a variation of the same structural and conceptual system.

limitations

However, one limitation of the project is that the complexity of production sometimes risks overshadowing the conceptual clarity. The technical and material challenges occasionally became dominant, requiring continuous reflection to ensure alignment with the research focus.

Another challenge is the communication of semi-functionality itself, which can be misinterpreted as incompleteness rather than intention. Future development could therefore focus more explicitly on how this condition is communicated to the user or viewer.

contribution to spatial design

The project is relevant to spatial design because it explores how objects do not only occupy space, but actively define and structure it. A table is not only a surface for use, but also a framework for social interaction and spatial organisation. By destabilising its expected functionality, the project reveals how meaning, behaviour, and interaction are shaped by material conditions rather than fixed definitions.

In a contemporary design context where objects are often expected to be efficient, resolved, and clearly defined, this project proposes an alternative approach in which ambiguity, transition, and activation are allowed to exist as part of design language. The work also contributes to ongoing discussions in spatial design regarding authorship, user participation, and the boundary between object and system.

The contribution of this project to spatial design lies in its reframing of function as a relational and constructed condition rather than a fixed property. By treating objects as systems rather than isolated artefacts, the project expands how design can be understood, not only as problem-solving, but also as a framework for negotiation, activation, and perception.



[Fig 52.] AI-generated picture of one of the trays on another table

conclusion

The project answers its research questions by proposing that an object becomes functional not through inherent properties alone, but through activation within a specific context. Function is relational rather than inherent and emerges through interaction between object, user, and environment.

Furthermore, aesthetics can operate as a functional component by shaping perception and influencing how usability is understood. The project therefore suggests that function should be understood not as a fixed attribute, but as a condition that is continuously negotiated through material, context, and use.



[Fig 53.] final result

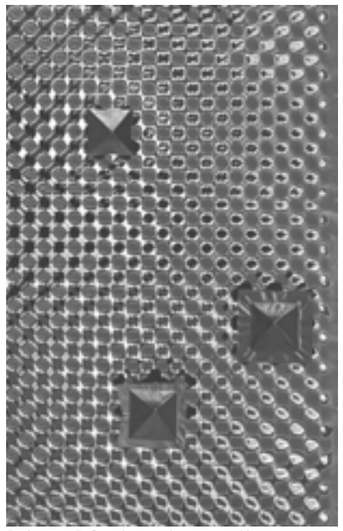


[Fig 54.] final result - Details

future research

Future research could further explore semi-functionality in dynamic systems where function changes over time or through interaction. It would also be relevant to investigate how users interpret ambiguity in real environments, and how communication strategies can support or intentionally disrupt understanding of function.

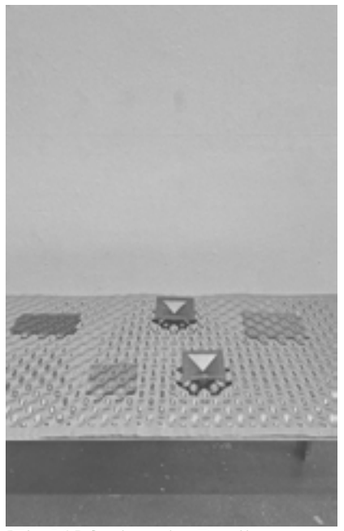
Additionally, the concept could be extended into architectural or larger spatial scales, where functional relationships become even more distributed and complex.



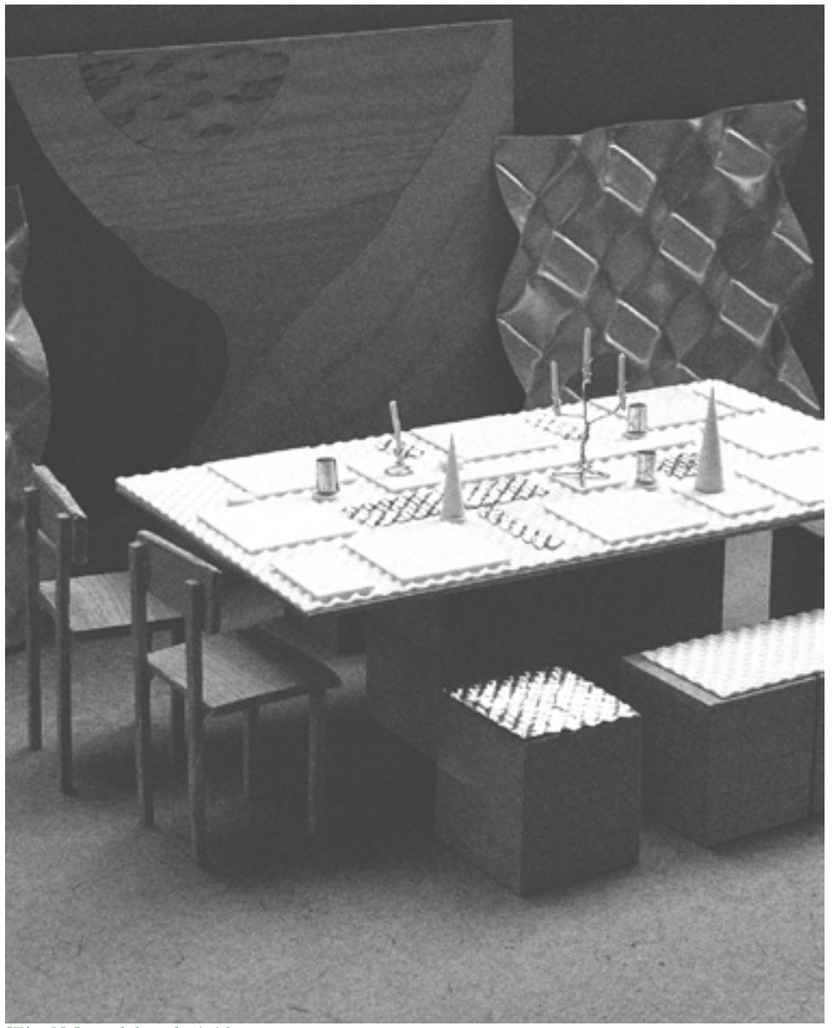
[Fig 55.] final result - Details



[Fig 57.] the bowls in making



[Fig 56.] final result - Details



[Fig 58.] model scale 1:10

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